Vafa Behnam

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Department of Economics
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Placement Director: Prashant Bharadwaj prbharadwaj@ucsd.edu
Placement Assistant: Andrew Flores aflores@ucsd.edu

Education

University of California, San Diego 2021–2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Economics

Brown University 2016–2020
B.A. in Mathematics-Economics
B.A. in Computer Science

Fields

Primary: Trade, Development

Secondary: Macroeconomics, Economic History

References

Professor Sam Bazzi *(Co-Chair)*
sbazzi@ucsd.edu

Professor Fabian Eckert *(Co-Chair)*
fpe@ucsd.edu

Professor Munseob Lee
munseoblee@ucsd.edu

Professor Fabian Trottner
ftrottner@ucsd.edu

Honors and Fellowships

Best Graduate Student Paper, Empirical Investigations in International Trade (EIIT) Conference 2026
Teaching Assistant Excellence Award, UC San Diego 2024
Advancement to Candidacy Fellowship, UC San Diego 2024
Graduate Research Fellowship, UC San Diego 2022, 2023
Regents Fellowship, UC San Diego 2021
Undergraduate Teaching and Research Award, Brown University 2017

Teaching Experience

As Head Instructor

University of California, San Diego
Principles of Macroeconomics Summer 2025
Rated 4.33/5.0 in student evaluations

As Teaching Assistant

Brown University
Machine Learning (Computer Science) Spring 2019

University of California, San Diego *(Economics unless noted)*
Short Run Macroeconomics Fall 2024
Microeconomics B Fall 2022, Summer 2024
Operations Research Spring 2024

Decision Making Under Uncertainty — Winter 2024
Econometrics C — Fall 2023
Industrial Organization — Spring 2023, Summer 2023
Econometrics A — Winter 2023, Summer 2023
Microeconomics A — Winter 2022
Business Analytics Capstone (Rady School of Management) — Spring 2026
Applied Urban Economics for Planning and Development (Urban Studies and Planning) — Fall 2025, Winter 2026
Introduction to the Real Estate and Development Process (Urban Studies and Planning) — Summer 2024

Employment

National Bureau of Economic Research, Full Time Research Assistant – Cambridge, MA — May 2020 – Aug 2021

Blue Cross and Blue Shield of Rhode Island, Data Analyst – Providence, RI — June 2018 – Sep 2018

Volunteering

Rhode Island State Prison, Minimum and Medium Security Facilities, GED Mathematics Teaching Assistant – Cranston, RI — June 2017-Jan 2018

Job Market Paper

When Does Trade Protection Help? Evidence from the Rise of American Manufacturing

When does trade protection boost growth and when does it harm growth? I study this question in the context of US industrialization in the 19th century. I develop a novel empirical design leveraging county-product variation in exposure to nationwide tariffs based on distance to international ports, using newly digitized tariff, import price and railway freight data. Exploiting a nationwide fiscal shock that suddenly raised tariffs for reasons unrelated to local industry conditions, I find protection reduces output growth for products close to the technological frontier but increases growth for products far behind it. I also find protection shifts patent activity towards far-from-frontier products, suggesting a reshaping of comparative advantage. A model of trade and innovation with variable markups generates these empirical results: for close-to-frontier products, protection substitutes for innovation as a source of market power; for further-behind products, protection instead makes the market contestable enough that the domestic producer can capture the rents from innovation. This model provides an imperfect-competition rationale for infant industry protection distinct from the usual learning-by-doing justification. I conclude by studying the welfare effects of trade, which can be negative unlike in workhorse trade models.

Working Papers

Did 2018 Tariffs Boost Manufacturing Growth? A Local Industry Approach

What were the impacts of the 2018 Trump tariff hike on manufacturing growth? Motivated by gravity theory, I develop an empirical strategy that exploits cross-state variation in pre-treatment sectoral import volumes, which generates differential exposure to nationwide tariff increases. I find a $1 tariff-induced reduction in imports raises output by $0.63 at the state-sector level. Accounting for a number of spatial spillover and general equilibrium channels, I estimate an implied nationwide manufacturing output gain from import protection of $69.5 to $127.5 billion. However, I find a $1 retaliation-induced reduction in exports results in a $3.4 loss in output, roughly five times the per-dollar output gain from import protection. A back-of-the-envelope calculation implies an aggregate loss of $177.8 billion, suggesting export losses are larger than the gains from import protection.

Works in Progress

Assembling an Industry: The Effects of India's Electronics Drive

I study India's 2012 Modified Special Incentive Package Scheme (MSIPS), which offered a 25% capital expenditure subsidy to electronics and semiconductor manufacturers at a time when nearly all chips and half of consumer electronics were imported. Using plant-level data from the Annual Survey of Industries, I employ an event study to estimate the effects of this policy. Treated plants experience a large and persistent increase in total factor productivity in quantities (TFPQ), with no evidence of local spillovers. Markups rise modestly in the long run but not in the short run, suggesting the subsidy is mildly anticompetitive over time. Using an aggregation framework (Levinsohn and Petrin 2012), I find this policy led to a 1.4% increase in aggregate productivity in the formal manufacturing sector in India, driven almost entirely by the direct productivity effect rather than reallocative effects across plants.